which Akbar enjoyed listening to. It was Mirza Aziz Koka who was usually asked to read the book aloud to the Padshah, and the mirza, despite his opposition to the farman, was so pleased with the book that he asked the priests for a copy for himself. Some of the other Muslim courtiers were more cynical, and scoffed that Christ's miracles were due to his excellent skills as a physician, rather than his miraculous powers. But what caused the greatest interest at court, and in the city, was a painting, a copy of the 'miraculous' Virgin of Santa Maria del Popolo, said to have been painted by the evangelist St Luke.

The Jesuits had obtained this image two years previously but had dared not exhibit it earlier because they were altogether too aware of the Padshah's voracious appetite for European paintings, and feared he would requisition it. Now, in January 1601, they exhibited their precious painting, more than 5 feet tall, in their makeshift chapel and the effect it had on the city was electrifying. People left their shops and their work to rush to the chapel and by the evening there was a jostling throng of more than 2,000 in the streets outside the chapel. With a fine flair for the dramatic, the Jesuits placed the image on the altar between two tall lighted candles and covered it with two veils. When the people saw the painting of a pale, moon-faced, melancholic Virgin pointing towards the child Jesus, who stared directly out of it, they were affected, said the Jesuits, 'in a manner that was wholly miraculous'. By the third day, the mullahs and the noblemen were rushing to see the image as well. This set off a deluge of people clamouring to view the image, 'people of every sort and quality', and those who would have 'deemed it discreditable to enter a Christian church' so that soon daily attendance had exceeded 10,000. It was not long, naturally, before Akbar heard about the image and asked for it to be brought to the palace. This the Jesuits did in the middle of the night, so as not to cause any commotion. They carried the image, draped and veiled as before, and presented it to the Padshah in his private quarters. Akbar came down from his throne and bowed low to the image, calling forward all his noblemen to approach the painting too. The Padshah told the Jesuits pointedly that his father, Humayun, would have greatly appreciated such an image if it had been presented to him but the Jesuits feigned sudden deafness and turned the conversation to other matters. Nonetheless, the Jesuits agreed to leave the painting in the palace overnight so that Akbar might show it to his wives and daughters, while telling them about the story of the Virgin Mary. All the